MAICON FORWARD

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(AI-Generated Session Notes)

The Architect, The Orchestrator, and The Apprentice: Rethinking Work in the Age of AI and Agents

Date & time: Oct. 14, 8:30-9:15 AM
Track: Keynote



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Session Description

AI is reshaping work at every level of the organization. As intelligent agents take on more of the tasks once performed by humans, the future of business may belong to three emerging roles: the architect, who designs AI-native systems of work; the orchestrator, who directs humans and machines toward outcomes; and the apprentice, who learns judgment in a world where traditional entry-level work is disappearing.

In this keynote, Paul Roetzer presents a new framework for understanding how AI and agents will transform business, leadership, and talent development.

He explores what happens when AI compresses the traditional career ladder, why judgment becomes the most valuable skill in the organization, and what leaders must do now to build smarter systems, stronger teams, and more resilient paths to expertise.

Key Quote

> *"If AI does the work people once learned from, how will organizations develop future managers, experts, and executives?"* **- Paul Roetzer**

Session Summary

Paul Roetzer, founder and CEO of SmarterX and Marketing AI Institute, opened MAICON 2026 by taking the audience back to his first job out of school in 2000 at a local marketing and PR firm. There he learned by doing: writing press releases, media pitches, proposals, and research reports, and building strategy knowledge by sitting in meetings and reading everything he could. He noted that everything he did back then can now be done by AI better, faster, and cheaper, and that had ChatGPT existed in 2000, he likely never would have gotten his start in marketing.

That realization frames the central question of the keynote: if AI does the work people once learned from, how will organizations develop future managers, experts, and executives? Roetzer grounded this in his Marketing AI Industry Council research with Google Cloud and the human-centered principles of his Responsible AI Manifesto. He recalled a law firm partner asking whether they still needed to hire associates, and his response, asking who the partners would be in 10 years, which reframed the room's thinking.

Roetzer then outlined what he expects with high confidence: AI labs will keep accelerating, agents will become more reliable and autonomous, and within 12 months AI will perform at an A-player level on tasks that take a qualified expert five or more hours. Work will compress as senior experts do the work of junior staff and roles blur across marketing, sales, and operations. He warned that if efficiency rises while growth stays flat, organizations need fewer people, which is why AI must be treated as a growth and innovation tool, and why leaders must decide when humans stay in the lead even when AI could take over.

Inspired by a brief encounter with a scientist and his apprentice at NASA Glenn Research Center, Roetzer introduced three emerging roles. The architect designs the systems, the workflows, governance, and human-machine operating models, illustrated by a Stripe job posting for a forward-deployed AI accelerator. The orchestrator runs the systems, directing agents and human collaborators and evaluating outputs. The apprentice learns within the systems, developing judgment through observation, mentorship, experimentation, and access to how decisions are made, which turns entry-level hiring from a source of affordable labor into an investment in future value.

Roetzer was clear that his goal was not to prove this framework is right, but to convince the audience that the traditional framework is broken. He closed with Shopify CEO Tobi Lütke's reflections on learning through apprenticeship and making AI use transparent, and urged leaders to communicate a vision for the future of work, focus on the people side of AI transformation, and invest in the next generation of marketers.

Key Takeaways

- **The traditional career ladder is breaking.** As AI absorbs the research, drafting, and execution that once trained junior talent, organizations must rethink how they develop future managers, experts, and executives.
- **Use AI for growth, not just efficiency.** If efficiency and productivity rise while growth and demand stay flat, organizations need fewer people, so leaders must treat AI as a growth and innovation tool to keep creating career opportunities.
- **Work is compressing from both ends.** Senior staff with domain expertise can now do the work of junior staff, while marketers, salespeople, and ops professionals increasingly take on each other's work.
- **Three roles for AI-forward teams.** The architect designs the systems, the orchestrator runs them by directing agents and humans, and the apprentice develops judgment by learning within them.
- **Decide when humans stay in the lead.** Just because AI can take the lead doesn't mean it should, so organizations need ground rules for when a human must remain in the lead.
- **Make AI work visible so others can learn.** Apprentices need access to how decisions are made and problems are solved, which requires leaders to be more open about how they work with AI.